

SKILLNEST

Assignment Submission Report

Mini Product Platform Challenge

Assignment	Web Developer & UI/UX — Mini Product Platform Challenge
Product	SkillNest — Course discovery and enrollment platform
Tech Stack	React · Node.js · Express · MongoDB · Tailwind CSS
Submitted to	SmarrtifAI Learning

This report covers all four parts of the assignment:

Part	What was built	Status
1	UI/UX Wireframes — 5 screens designed before development	■ Done
2	WordPress marketing site on Hostinger — 4 pages	■ Done
3	MERN web application with auth, CRUD, enrollment	■ Done
4	Deployment — Vercel + Render + Hostinger	■ Done

Part 1 — What is SkillNest?

SkillNest is a website where students can browse short courses and workshops, sign up for an account, and enroll in courses they want to take. Admins can add, edit, or remove courses from a dashboard.

How it works — step by step:

- A student visits the website and sees a list of available courses
- They create a free account (or log in if they already have one)
- They click on a course to see the full details — lessons, instructor, price
- They click Enroll Now — the course is saved to their personal dashboard
- An admin can log in separately and add new courses, edit existing ones, or delete them

Pages in the app:

Page	What it shows
Landing Page	Homepage with featured courses and a welcome message
Courses	Full list of all courses with search and category filters
Course Detail	All info about one course — lessons list and enroll button
Login / Register	Sign in or create a new account
My Dashboard	The student's enrolled courses and account info
Admin Dashboard	Add, edit, delete courses — and see all users

Tech used:

What	Technology	Why
Frontend (the website)	React + Tailwind CSS	Fast, modern, looks good on all screen sizes
Backend (the server)	Node.js + Express	Handles logins, course data, enrollment
Database	MongoDB	Stores users, courses, enrollments
Login system	JWT tokens	Secure — no passwords sent after login
Deployment	Vercel + Render	Both free — easy to deploy from GitHub

Part 2 — UI/UX Wireframes

Before writing any code, wireframes were drawn for all 5 required screens. These act like a blueprint — they show where every button, heading, and section will go before anything is built.

The full annotated wireframe document is in WIREFRAMES.pdf (included separately).

Screens designed:

Screen	What it contains
01 — Landing Page	Big headline, stats, 3 featured course cards, feature highlights, call-to-action button
02 — Login / Register	Two forms side by side — one to log in, one to create a new account
03 — Course Listing	Search bar, category buttons (Design / Dev / Marketing...), grid of course cards
04 — Course Detail	Course description, instructor name, lesson list, price, and enroll button in a sidebar
05 — Admin Dashboard	Stats row, table of all courses with Edit and Delete buttons, form popup to add a course

Design choices:

- Dark background (#0a0a0f) with orange (#f97316) as the brand color — energetic and modern
- Clash Display font for headings — distinctive and memorable
- Course cards show the level (Beginner / Intermediate / Advanced) with a colored badge
- The enroll sidebar stays fixed while you scroll — the button is always visible
- Admin-only links only appear in the navbar if you're logged in as an admin
- Search results update as you type — no need to press Enter

Part 3 — WordPress Marketing Site

A separate marketing website was built on WordPress, hosted on Hostinger. This is the public-facing site that introduces SkillNest to visitors. It links through to the main MERN app for enrollment.

The 4 pages:

Page	What's on it
Home	Hero banner, stats, 3 featured course cards, why SkillNest, testimonials, sign-up CTA
About	Mission statement, founding story, instructor team cards, company values
Courses	All 6 courses shown as cards — each links to the course page on the MERN app
Contact	Contact form (name, email, message), email address, response time info

Plugins installed:

Plugin	What it does
Astra Theme	Clean, lightweight theme — works well with Elementor
Elementor	Drag-and-drop page builder — used to build all 4 pages visually
WPForms Lite	Adds the contact form on the Contact page
Yoast SEO	Sets page titles and descriptions for Google
W3 Total Cache	Makes the site load faster

How WordPress connects to the MERN app:

- Every 'Enroll Now' button on WordPress links to the React app's /register page
- Course cards link directly to the course detail page on the MERN app
- The header has a 'Launch App' button that opens the main platform
- Same orange color and fonts used on both sites for visual consistency

Part 4 — MERN Web Application

The main platform is a full-stack web app built with the MERN stack (MongoDB, Express, React, Node.js). Here is everything it can do:

Features:

Feature	How it works
Sign up / Log in	Creates an account or logs in — a token is saved so you stay logged in
Browse courses	Shows all courses — filter by category or level, or search by name
Course detail	See the full course — lessons, instructor, price — then click Enroll
Enroll in a course	One click — the course appears in your dashboard instantly
My Dashboard	Shows all your enrolled courses and your account details
Admin — add course	Fill in a form — title, description, price, etc. — course goes live
Admin — edit course	Click Edit on any row in the table — change any field and save
Admin — delete	Click Delete — confirms before removing permanently
Admin — view users	Switch to the Users tab to see everyone who's signed up

How login security works:

- When you log in, the server creates a JWT token (like a digital pass) and sends it back
- Your browser saves this token — it's sent with every future request automatically
- The token expires after 7 days — you'll need to log in again after that
- Passwords are never stored as plain text — they're scrambled with bcrypt before saving
- Admin-only routes check your role on the server — you can't sneak in from the browser

Part 5 — API Endpoints (Backend Routes)

The backend has 11 routes split across three groups. Anyone can use the public ones. The rest need you to be logged in, and some need you to be an admin.

Login & Registration

Method	URL	Who can use it	What it does
POST	/api/auth/register	Anyone	Create a new account
POST	/api/auth/login	Anyone	Log in and get a token
GET	/api/auth/me	Logged in	Get your own account info

Courses

Method	URL	Who can use it	What it does
GET	/api/courses	Anyone	See all published courses
GET	/api/courses/:id	Anyone	See one course in full detail
POST	/api/courses	Admin only	Add a new course
PUT	/api/courses/:id	Admin only	Edit an existing course
DELETE	/api/courses/:id	Admin only	Delete a course forever
POST	/api/courses/:id/enroll	Logged in	Enroll in that course
GET	/api/courses/admin/all	Admin only	See all courses including drafts

Users

Method	URL	Who can use it	What it does
GET	/api/users/dashboard	Logged in	Your enrolled courses + profile
GET	/api/users	Admin only	List of everyone who signed up
GET	/api/users/stats	Admin only	Total user and admin counts

Part 6 — Deployment

The app is split into three separate deployments. Each one is free to host and can be updated independently.

What	Where it's hosted	Cost
React frontend	Vercel	Free
Node.js backend	Render	Free
MongoDB database	MongoDB Atlas	Free (M0 tier)
WordPress site	Hostinger	Free / Basic plan

How to deploy — step by step:

Step	What to do
1	Create a free MongoDB Atlas account → make a cluster → copy the connection string
2	Push the skillnest/ folder to a new GitHub repo
3	Go to render.com → New Web Service → connect GitHub → root folder: backend → deploy
4	In the Render shell, run: node seed.js — this adds the demo courses and accounts
5	Go to vercel.com → New Project → connect GitHub → root folder: frontend → deploy
6	Add VITE_API_URL = your Render URL as an environment variable on Vercel
7	Log into Hostinger → install WordPress → build 4 pages using Elementor
8	Update the CLIENT_URL variable on Render to point to your Vercel URL

One thing to know about the free tier:

The Render free plan 'sleeps' your backend after 15 minutes of no activity. The first request after that takes about 30 seconds to wake up. This is normal — just mention it in your video.

Part 7 — Demo Data & Submission

Running node seed.js fills the database with everything needed to demo the app without manually creating anything.

What gets created:

What	Details
Admin account	Email: admin@skillnest.com Password: admin123
Student account	Email: student@skillnest.com Password: student123
6 sample courses	Design, Development, Marketing, Data Science, Business, Photography
2 pre-enrollments	The student account is already enrolled in 2 courses for demo purposes

Courses included in the seed data:

Course	Category	Level	Price
UI/UX Design Fundamentals	Design	Beginner	■999
Full Stack Web Development (MERN)	Development	Intermediate	■2,499
Digital Marketing Mastery	Marketing	Beginner	■799
Data Science with Python	Data Science	Intermediate	■1,999
Business Communication & Leadership	Business	Beginner	■599
Mobile Photography & Editing	Photography	Beginner	■399

Submission checklist:

Item	Status
MERN app — React frontend	■ Complete
MERN app — Node.js/Express backend	■ Complete
MERN app — MongoDB database	■ Complete
UI/UX Wireframes (5 screens)	■ In WIREFRAMES.pdf
WordPress site (4 pages)	■ On Hostinger
Deployment — all 3 tiers	■ Vercel + Render + Hostinger
GitHub repository	■ Public repo

Submission PDF (this document)	■ This file
Short video walkthrough (1–3 min)	■ Record separately

Video outline (1–3 minutes):

- Show the WordPress site — Home, About, Courses, Contact pages
- Open the MERN app — browse courses, register a new account
- Enroll in a course — show it appear in the dashboard
- Log in as admin — create a new course, edit it, delete it
- Show the GitHub repo and mention the live URLs

Links & Credentials

Fill these in after deployment:

Live URLs

What	URL
React App (Vercel)	https://____.vercel.app
Backend API (Render)	https://skillnest-api.onrender.com
WordPress Site	https://____.hostinger.com
GitHub Repo	https://github.com/____/skillnest

Test Accounts

Role	Email	Password
Admin	admin@skillnest.com	admin123
Student	student@skillnest.com	student123

Quick test checklist:

- Go to /courses — you should see 6 course cards load from the database
- Register a new account — you should be redirected to the dashboard
- Enroll in a course — it should appear under My Courses in the dashboard
- Log out, log back in as admin — go to /admin
- Create a new course — it should appear in the course listing
- Edit that course — change the title and save
- Delete that course — it should disappear from the list
- Check /api/health in the browser — should return {'status':'OK'}

SkillNest — Mini Product Platform Challenge

Built with React · Node.js · Express · MongoDB · Tailwind CSS · WordPress